snared by lasso or shot with his lethal arrows. Every day soldiers at the edge of the circle moved in, holding lengths of bamboo fences, and the field became smaller, the area dense with blood, and fear, and the warm bodies of the frightened beasts. After five days, the great amirs and special courtiers were allowed to hunt and next came the attendants until, on the last day, ordinary foot soldiers and cavalrymen charged into the tight circle in a final, screaming orgy of bloodlust. At the end of the qumargha, the air rang with the silence of the dead animals, the earth was scorched and bloody, and there could have been no more effective demonstration of Akbar's might, the skill and fury of his warriors, and the wealth of Hindustan's great amirs.

The qumargha was not only extremely effective at demonstrating imperial power, it served as a training ground for the cavalry and infantrymen. There were few spaces more dangerous at the time than the dense, heaving circle of a qumargha, where swords flashed and arrows from the deadly accurate composite bows thudded into moving targets. It was a drill exercise in near battle conditions, and tested the soldiers' expertise as much as their bloodlust. Indeed, scores were sometimes settled in this incendiary field, an enemy quietly killed off amid the carnage.

Returning to Lahore after the qumargha, the Mughal troops arrived at the river Ravi, wide and unsoundable after the spring snow melt. Akbar plunged his horse into the river, obliging his retinue to do the same. As the horses swam against the current and the treacherous eddies, two men drowned. At each stage Akbar appeared to test not just himself but also his men, their loyalty to their emperor, and their courage which, when the Padshah was Akbar, was the very same thing.

At some point during his stay in the Lahore region, Akbar paid a visit to a venerable old man, the third Guru of a young religion which had gained followers with great speed. This was Guru Amar Das, ninety years old at the time, living at Goindwal on the banks of the river Beas. There are no records in the Persian biographies of the time regarding this meeting, but it is entirely plausible that Akbar would have wanted to visit this elderly man whose reputation for saintliness and social service was well established. It is Sikh tradition, rather, that lovingly recorded the meeting of the young Padshah and the old Guru. Guru Amar Das invited the Padshah to share in the communal kitchen, the langar, which was one of the three sanctioned activities of the faith, in addition to a place for worship (dharamsala) and congregational worship (sangat). The Guru's langar was especially famous